

# Faster!

**W**e've come a long way from the days of dial-up modems, frequent disconnects and pathetic Internet speeds to always-on, high speed connections where you can watch movies and play online games.

You're joking right?

Obviously. The promise of broadband in India still remains unrealised. Sure, if you've got the money, you can invest in expensive dedicated leased lines, VSATs and the like for your office or home and experience gut-wrenching speeds. There are more affordable alternatives: DSL and Cable Internet, both great technologies that can fulfil the promise of broadband.

But, they don't. These same technologies have let us down. Or to be more precise their service providers and implementers have let us down.

Early networks supported customers who used bandwidth in the range of 2-4 Kbps. This has changed. An average broadband customer today demands a minimum of 1 Mbps. So when service providers with older networks try to scale up to match the high requirements, reliability and performance issues creep in.

It's the classic chicken and the egg conundrum. Should the service providers ramp up infrastructure for users that don't exist yet? Or should they wait and get more users before they ramp up their infrastructure, which leads to poor quality of Service for the existing users.

The egg has hatched and the chicken is nowhere in sight. Users want high speed Internet access and are ready to pay for it. Especially considering the dial-up fees they pay to the telecom companies and their local Internet provider in any case.

So are we going to be stuck to our modems forever?

No. A solution is in sight. With the lowering costs of international bandwidth and the setting up of national high-speed backbones, the costs of upgrading infrastructure will become more feasible. But it's going to take some time.

Meanwhile the only 'real solution provider' is that one entity which currently controls all last mile connectivity—your local *cablewallah*. India has a very large cable TV penetration—it's much more than the telephone user base. The *cablewallah* is responsible for wiring our nation, so to speak, and with his lower operational costs and bundles of ingenuity, he's in just the right position to offer broadband to the starving consumer, neighbourhood by neighbourhood.

All that's left is for you to demand this service.



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“Should Internet service providers ramp up infrastructure for broadband users that don't exist yet?”